to be elected from north India in 2024, defeating the BJP in Sikar, Rajasthan; besides five others.

Baby's elevation wasn't entirely a smooth affair. The Bengal and Maharashtra units opposed the Kerala leader's nomination and suggested Bengal unit secretary Mohammed Salim's name instead. Salim declined and favoured Maharashtra veteran Ashok Dhawale. Former general secretary Prakash Karat finally had to smooth things out with the dissenters before Baby was "unanimously elected".

Talking to INDIA TODAY, Baby said his first priority would be to strengthen the cadre at the grassroots level nationally. "Without rebuilding the party, we won't achieve any of our political targets. It's only the CPI(M) and like-minded parties who can effectively fight the Modi government's communal agenda," says Baby.

BABY'S ELEVATION TO THE TOP POST WAS NOT A SMOOTH AFFAIR. FORMER CPI(M) CHIEF PRAKASH KARAT HAD TO INTERVENE TO ENSURE THAT HE WAS ELECTED "UNANIMOUSLY"

As expected, there was jubilation back in Kerala at Baby's ascension: he's only the second leader from the state to helm the party, after the late E.M.S. Namboothiripad (technically Karat is also from Kerala, but part of the Delhi unit). Former Left Front MP and social commentator Sebastian Paul is certain that he'll do well. "Baby is experienced, politically sensitive and listens to dissenting voices. In him, there is a good mix of EMS, Karat, Yechury along with Harkishan Surjeet's street savvy. He will be effective as a national leader, uncompromising in fighting the communal agenda of the Modi government," he says.

An altar boy-turned-Communist atheist at age 16, Baby had stints as national head of the CPI(M)'s youth wings before being sent to the Rajya Sabha in 1986, when he was just 32, and stayed for 12 years. But he had to wait till 2012 to enter the prized portals: the politburo. An "inconvenient proposition" to many for speaking his mind, he was sidelined in the state by both Pinarayi and his one-time rival and predecessor as Left CM, V.S. Achuthanandan. But it was under VS (2006-11) that he left his mark as an education reformer: his ministerial stint set rolling then-innovative ideas like IT exposure in government schools and steering curriculum design away from rote learning.

In his new innings, Baby cannot play by rote. Without a revival in West Bengal and Tripura, the CPI(M) stares at national irrelevance. But the party won only 5.7 per cent of the vote share in Bengal in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. Most of the cadre have migrated to either the Trinamool Congress or the BJP. In Tripura, too, a 12.4 vote share does not augur well.

Kerala, which votes in early 2026, also poses significant challenges. The CPI(M) hopes for a hat-trick. But there's a decade of anti-incumbency to live down, not to speak of the Enforcement Directorate tightening its noose around Pinarayi's family, an aggressive Congress, and the slow Catholic embrace of saffron. The faction-ridden state unit is also not without some of the classic signs of organisational decay: criminal nexus, corruption in the leadership, disillusionment in the cadre so clear that many have left political work. A lot to take on, but in Baby perhaps, they have the man for the job. ■



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WEST BENGAL

A RECAS

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

The West Bengal government's decision to conduct a fresh survey to identify Other Backward Classes (OBCs) has reignited the debate over reservation policies, social justice and political strategy. The move follows the Calcutta High Court's May 2024 ruling that scrapped the state's classification of 113 communities—predominantly Muslim—as OBCs, on grounds that religion seemed to be the criterion for their inclusion.

The West Bengal Commission for Backward Classes has now engaged two independent bodies—the Culture Research Institute (CRI) and the Bureau of Applied Economics and Statistics (BAES)—to conduct the fresh survey based on applications received from communities seeking OBC status.

Once the commission receives such applications, it conducts a survey itself or through designated agencies. Based on the results, the commission holds hearings before forwarding its recom-